

VIVIAN

Part I:

"That's all for today. Class dismissed."

As if on cue, people begin shuffling out the door. I haven't even started packing up my stuff yet. As I shove a binder into my backpack, a wave of listlessness washes over me. The semester's only started, and I'm already tired of it. Not the classes. Not the assignments. Just the repetition. As I walk out the door, I call Trevor. If I remember right, his shift should've finished half an hour ago.

"You finish work yet?"

"Yeah, I'll be there soon."

"What time?"

"5:45-ish, maybe?"

"Okay." I pause and try to remember the day of the week. It all feels like a blur. "Shoulders. We're doing shoulders today."

Trevor scoffs. "Why, Phoenix? It's not like it's useful."

"Shut up. Just come to Main Gym."

"No, no, we're going to South Hall."

"What? South Hall? Just come to the other place."

"Nah, the other guys are already there, so just deal with it."

The call ends, and I just lie on that bean bag in one of the buildings and let out a sigh. It's not like I'm excited about either gym. I just prefer the Main Gym. It's brighter. Cleaner.

South Hall is darker. Louder. And there's always that stupid line at the entrance.

I check the time. 5:12. So let's place a timer for thirty minutes.

I tell myself it's just another normal workout. Just another day.

Third year is around the time when you really should figure yourself out with life. Everyone starts talking about your plans and stuff. I'm no exception; I've been looking

for an internship and learning new things. But after that lecture, all I could think of is that one promise I made to Jace.

Every year, I come to Seattle and hang out with my friends there for Christmas and New Year. And, every year, I stay at Jace's house. We have this small party with his friends, but it always ends the same. He and I go back to his house, and on that ride we make some really cliché promises.

For him, he wants to work out more often.

For me, it's getting together with someone.

The funny thing is that Jace's always fine with his physique: slim and fast. He doesn't think he'd get much out of going to the gym.

Meanwhile, at this point, I really hate the idea of falling in love with someone. Back in high school, I'd been in a drawn out situationship for a few years. After it ended in the messiest way possible, I've never felt the urge to try again. For all of my college days, I decided to just focus on the academic stuff, and to not distract myself with any romantic flings.

That's what I tell myself, anyway.

I suddenly jerk awake as my alarm goes off. Seems I'd nodded off on a desk in the corner of the hallway. I stretch, the grogginess fading away. The other guys are waiting.

I wake up, walk to the gym, and meet up with everyone. Things proceed in a lethargic manner. I'm just going through the motions. I just want to get this day over with.

Trevor suddenly taps my shoulder. "Dude, that chick over there's pretty cute, huh?" I look up, half-listening, and suddenly the world melts away.

All I can see are her eyes. Those are the most beautiful eyes I have ever seen.

That feeling is uncanny. It's like when you lost something a long time ago, and you forgot about it. Then, you come across it again, and all the memories come rushing back. It's strange, because I've never met someone like this.

Suddenly, I look at Trevor, the guy who always pushes me to talk to new people. I know he's going to push me to talk to her, so I decide to beat him to the punch.

"Trevor, if I make this 70lbs, I'm gonna go talk to her."

"Yeah, sure, buddy." He rolls his eyes. His attention's already elsewhere.

But after crushing that weight, I am about to give up on it like always, but on the way out, I look at her again. I do not really get it, but I feel a push. Something just makes me walk towards her.

Those first few steps feel like the most awkward thing ever. I've never been so conscious about how I walk.

I take a deep breath and wave. "Hey, what is your name?"

"Oh, Vivian... How about you?"

"My name is Phoenix...I just want to say that you look pretty beautiful. Can I have your Insta?"

"Sure."

I give her my phone and my hand is shaking. Why is my hand shaking? It's like I just got out of the pool of ice.

She hands me back my phone, and I walk out in a daze. What just happened? I walk out feeling better than ever, and that night she follows back. It's weird. Where did all of that courage come from? After three years, how did I suddenly fall for someone so fast again?

What a fever dream.

Part II:

I wave goodbye to Trevor and begin trudging back to my dorm. We'd crushed another workout, and I was feeling like a million bucks. It feels like there's nothing that can bring me down.

Suddenly, my phone flashes with a text from Kai, my study partner.

Yo did you do q4 yet idk where to start even lmao

I sigh. I guess there's something that can still bring me down. Somehow, my Stats 200 homework had completely slipped my mind.

I turn around and begin heading towards the campus Starbucks. I find it's easiest to concentrate in a busier environment than cooped up in my dorm room. Also, a cup of coffee right now would go a long way.

An hour and two cups later, I've caught up with Kai. Question 4, it seems, is every bit as awful as he made it out to be. We get halfway through the problem before we call it there. I look up from my laptop, eyes strained from the work.

...Was she there this whole time?

Vivian is scrunched over a table, clattering away at the keyboard. She's probably in the same boat as I am.

Before I can overthink things, I stand up and walk over, but try to keep a distance. "Hey, Vivian! Didn't think you were here."

"Oh, hi!" She lights up a bit, like she's happy I said something. "Yeah, I needed coffee. I was just finishing up some stuff before I head back home. I need to get a headstart on my work and all."

"What are you doing?"

"Some code at work." She says it casually.

"Wait, are you in CS as well?"

"Yeah."

I take a step back, already half turned. *Say something else, damn it!*

"Um, nice. Okay, see you soon then."

When I walk out, I keep telling myself there was nothing to say, but I know that's a lie. *What are you building? What made you pick CS?*

Are you free later?

This paralysis only continues as the weeks go by. Our gym schedules usually line up, and I try not to miss a day. We talk a bit – small talk that usually starts with "How are you?" Courses, routines, whatever. I swear I could have just said anything.

But we remain distant. I'm too nervous to make an advance. Like seriously, Phoenix, why? It's like after that day, all my courage disappeared.

Every time I talk to her, I try to come up and talk to her, I try to think of something to impress her, but I can't.

The time I fell for her the hardest was when I saw her trying to reach for the cable machine. Vivian is shorter than me and I am no giant, so she had to tiptoe and hop to reach it. That was the cutest moment I've ever seen in all of my life. I fell for her so hard at that moment.

But it just feels like I wasn't ready to fall in love yet.

One day, I call my best friend, Adrian, back in my home town. We talk for a while, catching up.

"Dude, what's up?" I try to keep my tone nonchalant.

"What's up?" He scoffs. "Come on, man, it's my birthday."

"Uh. Yeah, I knew that. You want something for your big day? I'll get you anything you want, man."

"Oh, no need, bro." He pauses for a second. "There's this one game called *Broforce*. It's like... hold on, six dollars-ish?"

"That's it? Sure, I'll get it for you. No big deal."

"So what is *up* with you today..."

And so the conversation goes. It's funny how spending like five minutes with someone you like, you can talk for hours with your best bro. Well he hype me up, which is crazy but it is because I have not like anyone for a long time so he is just happy and hyping me up.

Before I know it, though, it all comes crashing down. Summer comes, and just like that, we never meet each other again. At least, as far as I know.

Logically, I am certain we'll never come across each other again. My gut, however, says that we'll meet again someday.

They are always arguing with each other.

And for a bit, we text briefly. I give it my best, but I feel that she doesn't feel the same way. Then, one day, she unfollowed me.

Was it something I said?

Was it something I didn't say?

Either way, it just sends me into a spiral. I know I messed up, but I'm not sure how. I coop myself inside my room for most of the day, distracting myself with games or useless projects. Even there, though, I can't escape. Even my dreams are about her.

My friends begin to reach out after a bit. Trevor hits me up, talking about how I haven't been attending the weekly basketball games. Kai asks if he can start training alongside me at the gym. Even Jace tells me he'll drive up to Vancouver and hang out for a bit next weekend. Though they don't show it, I know that they're trying to make me feel better. It does help me get me out of my room, at least.

Somehow, my parents know about it, too. It's like they have a sixth sense of knowing that I like someone. They're the only ones I confess to about Vivian. Not the full story, but enough.

That summer ends up being the second worst summer of my life. Right after that break up with Katy in high school. I keep trying to remind myself to focus on school. Academics. Not this romantic crap.

Bizarre things start to happen on my Korea trip on the way back to Vancouver. It's just a weird flight. I saw someone who looks exactly like her but much older, has a son and a family. What do I mean by older? Baggy eyes, messy hair, and wrinkles. I don't know, but

that just reminds me of Vivian if she is older. And still, I'm still falling hard for that idea. I really do want to grow old with her...

Why can't I get this girl out of my head?!

I just want Vivian to end up with someone who will fall in love with her till the day they die. Someone who is trying to be better for her and is always there for her.

Someone who understands that there are sunny days and there are rainy days. You can't really choose. All you can do is fall in love with the city anyway, no matter what happens.

I wanted to be that guy, but I never got the chance. Or, more specifically, I never gave myself that chance.

I keep reminding myself, "If it's meant for me, it will find me." Love will come when it comes.

I hate that line.

Part III:

The beginning of fourth year is rough because everywhere I go, I keep looking for her. Everything is going downhill. I couldn't renew my Visa this time without an interview, so no Seattle for this year, either. No visit to Jace. Trevor and my other friends are all heading back home, too, so I'll just be alone.

Well, no matter. I decide to make the best out of my time. I book a flight to Denver just two weeks before Christmas. *A vacation will clear my mind.*

The trip starts smoothly enough, until I reach the airport. Suddenly, I find myself dealing with a 70-dollar carry-on fee I hadn't planned for. That's already plenty of money for a trip I just started. It's annoying, but I brush it off. As the flight starts and ends without any issues, I tell myself that the hard part is over.

It isn't.

As soon as I get out of the airport, I book an Uber to an Airbnb I have secured just a week earlier. I went cheap, thinking I wouldn't be there much anyway. When I open the door, I see dirty snow on the floor. I think I could deal with it until I turned on the light. The bed is filthy, the dishes were still in the sink, and the place felt neglected in a way that goes beyond a mere mess.

I didn't even think to unpack. The first thing I do is to open my laptop and get myself a new Airbnb. Thus, I spent the first day, huddled on a worn-out couch with a tiny heater, watching *Tom and Jerry Adventure* without sleeping until I could check into the new place.

I arrive early next morning, and things start looking up. The new Airbnb was everything the first one wasn't. A downtown apartment with an incredible view, a bath, a huge TV, and a couch that finally feels like home.

Guess I shouldn't have gone the cheap route. Seems like every time I chose something only because it was cheap, it always came back to bite me.

Despite how perfect the place was, it's languid. I quickly fell into a routine. Coding in my free time, working out, cooking my own meals, and spending my evenings alone walking the street or by the river. Every day feels heavier than the last. The 21st was manageable. The 22nd felt empty. The 23rd was unbearable.

All I could think of was Vivian. I wonder if she's relaxing with her family. I miss her, but I don't want to admit it. So I choose an alternative like swiping Bumble or Tinder and talking to other girls. I try to go on dates, but I chicken out at the last second.

On Christmas Eve, I feel dead inside. Maybe it's a combination of drinking, watching a sad movie, and being alone for so long, but without even thinking, I reached for my phone and text Vivian two words.

Merry Christmas.

I stare at my phone with half-open eyes. I don't know what I was really expecting. Reconnection, I guess. Maybe a "Happy New Year" or something. More likely, though, is that she ignores it.

She blocks me.

It is painful in a way I can't properly describe. It's like there is a void in your chest. You physically feel like there is a hole in your chest. You lose the motivation to go out. So, I use my alternative account to send her a final message about what I have been thinking over the last few months, and then tell her to block me after.

Obviously, she does the next day.

I crossed the line. I understand why she blocks me. Christmas Eve and Christmas come and go. Before I know it, New Year's is just around the corner.

On the last day of the trip and year, I open up Google Maps and look for a spot to treat myself. There's a nice Japanese restaurant called Lonely Mouth for one last meal before going to 2026. It was a great meal, delicious and expensive, but the name felt like a bad joke.

I try to be happy for Vivian and push everything under the rug. I keep telling myself to let go, and I wish her the best even without me.

But I am lying to myself.

I hate that I am this stubborn and this patient at the same time. I wish I could just forget about her the way my friends move on from their breakups. Clean. Fast.

I used to be like that, too, back in my past relationship.

I just hate how Vivian and I seem so unfinished.

I wish we had more time to actually know each other. But nothing happened.

Part IV:

So at the beginning of January, I can really see that I am losing myself. That is why I am sitting here in this crowded room, joining West Coast Dev Day for the whole weekend.

Trevor and I decide to work on a hardware trash sorting idea. It'll require me to learn a few new things, but I'm fine with that. I just need something to distract myself. With the bad luck in my love life, maybe I can be lucky here.

During those twenty-four hours, our table was a mess of wires, burnt solder, loose components, and improvised fixes. It was our first time soldering, and what we thought were wiring mistakes turned out to be weak joints that forced us to redo entire sections while the clock kept ticking. When we ran out of tape, we used stickers. When the button would not sit properly inside the enclosure, we dropped a small stone inside just to hold it in place. None of it was elegant. Most of it felt unstable.

But somehow, after hours of debugging drivers, reading scattered documentation, and watching tutorials, the system finally held together.

After the final pitch, we actually make the shortlist. For our efforts, that's as far as we get.

It is fair. Our project is not as strong as the top three. But something still shifts inside me. We get so close, and it still does not work out. The whole time I try to be polite, clapping and wishing them the best, but I really can not.

Why is it always like this?

Why is it always not working out?

Can something go right, just *once*?

After the hackathon, I feel utterly drained and demotivated. For the first time, I catch myself just... waiting for something to happen. Waiting for a sign. Waiting for the universe to give me something. Every small coincidence feels bigger than it is. I hold onto it.

Some days, I crash again. Some days, I calm down and hold onto deluded hopes.

Throughout all of this, I start writing my thoughts down. At first, it's just random quotes I create or things I come up with or see online. Slowly, they turn into stories about my life and how I see things. I organize them. Without planning it, they begin to form something

coherent. I never meant to write a book. I do not even have the experience for it. But every time I write something, part of me feels lighter.

When I begin editing, I realize something unexpected. My life is more interesting than I thought.

I start gaining confidence again. I begin to look at the problems I buried years ago. The ones that slowly ate at my self esteem without me noticing. It is strange to finally see them clearly.

I start looking at Vivian's situation differently. Letting go feels easier than before. I used to say I hoped she would be happy with someone else, but deep down I always thought it would still be me.

Now, after writing everything down and letting it run its course, I accept that we'll never see each other again. And even if we do, she may not look at me the same way. That thought is sad, but I am okay with it. It is strange because a part of me still holds on, which is the opposite.

I don't stop loving her. I just accept the fact that there will never be an "us".

So if there is something on my mind, I start noting them down in my notebook. Whenever I feel overwhelmed, I go on a run or a walk.

Then I choose to let go. So I leave the notebook somewhere along the road to the beach at my university. I wrote everything in it without any intention of keeping it. It was always my plan to give it to someone else. And since I cannot give it to the person I wrote it for, I just hide it.

I guess everyone has a different way to deal with this.

Part V:

I usually run along Point Grey Rd, but today I'm taking it slow. I don't know everything, it just feels warm and freezing at the same time. Like the sun shines so bright, but why am I freezing?

Regardless, the path is beautiful as always: the blue ocean, the sky... everything is just perfect. But after walking for around one hour straight just to get to a beach, it seems like everyone has the same idea of spending time lying here or playing volleyball.

It was a quick thought earlier because I just wanted to get out of the house and do something. I am not prepared for any of that, let alone joining in a random game with other people. So, walking alongside the concrete pathway it is. It's just weird how I am just a guy wearing all black, a jacket with running shoes instead of flip flops.

Knowing two of my friends got pooped on by some seagulls earlier this week, the concrete road is a battlefield, avoiding any artillery from above. Yeah, those pesky seagulls... Nothing like the ravens that I used to feed earlier that year who never left any business anywhere near my rented place.

My mind drifts back to my future. Soon, I will need to make a decision. A career-defining decision, to be sure. Should I stay in Vancouver, or return to my home town? It's not like this place has done anything great for me. It was full of missed opportunities like that hackathon shortlist, the grades, the future, and...

Am I even ready after 4 years of university?

Then, I look down toward the beach, near the iron chairs facing the ocean, and I notice someone familiar. I can't pinpoint who she is at first, but something in my chest tightens. I instinctively stop walking.

A biker swerves past me and yells for stopping so suddenly.

And right at that moment, she turns around and looks at me.

Our eyes meet, and my heart skips, and then it clicks.

Those eyes. They're Vivian's.

I guess we both know it's too awkward to keep staring at each other, especially when we clearly recognize one another, or at least I know she recognizes me. She stands up from the log and begins walking toward me, and I do the same thing.

Why *now*? Why, after so many months?

"Hi," she said.

"Hey. Just taking a walk and enjoying the view."

"It's a great day for it."

"So, it has been a while, did you do anything new...? Like... something cool?"

Why did I say that? Am I back at square one? I learned not to ask "How are you?" every time, and somehow I just rephrased it in a slightly fancier and awkward form.

"Well, y'know, it was spring break. I went out and just hung out with my friends. You know, just go out and eat and do stuff... How about you?"

"Similar boat here. Like, the hanging out with friends part. We actually went hiking in North Van. It was snowing like crazy, and our car died when we got back to the parking lot, haha."

"Wait, what?"

"Yeah, we had to jump-start our battery with this kit... Six grown-ups holding a bunch of wires while finding a YouTube video and chatGPT to know what to do.... Luckily, some old white guy knew we were clueless and got us out of there."

"Yeah... I would've panicked."

"Well, yeah, I got home safely, thankfully... Nice seeing you again, Vivian."

"It is nice to meet you again... Phoenix, right?"

"Yeah, you got it. Hope I see you around."

"Oh, goodbye..."

After less than three minutes, we start moving in opposite directions. Or rather, she does. I am still standing there, barely walking, watching her drift away.

Seriously, Phoenix.

You waited more than a year, hoping that one day you would see her again, and this is how you end it?

All those times you told yourself that if you ever saw her again, you would go all in and actually talk.

Just like that first encounter at the gym. But I do not chase her.

I don't even speak. I just stand there thinking of all the "what if" scenarios in my head.

Hey Vivian... can I say one last thing?

In my head, she stops. That's all I allow myself.

I'm sorry I made you uncomfortable. I understand why you blocked me. I crossed a line.

Out of eight billion people... I'm sorry you had to run into the most annoying one.

At first, I really did want another chance. I don't anymore.

I care about you, and I had to learn that caring about someone doesn't mean you're meant to be with them.

I just hope you're happy. That's all.